

# Sprezzatura



*Sprezzatura* is a role-playing game inspired by Renaissance culture and thought from Italian academies and courts. This project is still at its embrional state, so take this notes are purely speculative. Instead of providing a comprehensive rulebook, I have been experimenting with a small knowledge base resembling a wiki-like website. Each page is interlinked with each other, providing easy referencing for players and Game Master. A [Glossary](#) of terms is available, dispensing a quick explanation of terms used in *Sprezzatura* with a reference to more widely-used terminology in the TTRPG community.

This project is part of my doctorate project *A Whirlpool of Imaginary Sounds* at [Orpheus Instituut](#). For further information, don't hesitate to reach out via email at [nicholas.cornia\[at\]orpheusinstituut.be](mailto:nicholas.cornia[at]orpheusinstituut.be)

Illustrations are mostly derived from the 15th century [Visconti-Sforza tarots](#).

# What is this game about?



Following Jared Sorensen's [Three Big Questions](#) I would like to introduce *Sprezzatura* as a game about **cooperative storytelling**, **unexpected narratives**, **character growth** and **wit**. The game is based on an esoteric game-engine of my invention called the *Resonance System*: a cooperative dice-poll system inspired by [Pythagorean intervals](#) and the [Harmony of the Spheres](#). Furthermore, at the players' disposal comes a metacurrency system based on [Major Arcana](#) and [Minor Arcanas](#) tarot cards. Finally, the long-term growth of the story and characters is regulated by a parallel board-game similar to the [Royal Game of the Goose](#). Interaction and sharing agency on the story with other players is encouraged by the *Resonance System*, decentralizing the usual role of the Game Master between all participant at the table.

# Game-mechanics



At the core of *Sprezzatura* lies a original dice resolution called the *Resonance System*. During a **Challenge**, a moment of uncertainty in the conversation between the participants at the table called the **Gathering**, the **Host** will ask the active player to describe their action.

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## Core Mechanics: the *Resonance System*



The building blocks of this unique resolution mechanics are:

- Rules of **Consonances** describing how to assemble **Triumphs** by pairing together dice and the four **Temperaments** as main attributes.
- **Minor Arcanas** are a form of metacurrency in the form of cards that a player can use to increase their chances of success.
- A player can rely on their own **Resonance Pool**, a latent pool of previously unused dice that can be used to assemble Consonances with the current dice pool. Other players can help by allowing the active player to draw from their Resonance Pool.

## Emulating oppositions: Wheels





# Act



A gaming session of about 3 hours is considered to be an Act. During this time period, the [Gathering](#) will play out a series of [Scenes](#).

# Aspect



A short sentence defining a PC's Backgrounds (Past), Bonds (Present) and Drives (Future). If a certain Aspect applies on the given [Challenge](#), the active player can invoke it to add a [Minor Arcana](#) card in their dice pool, increasing their chances of success.

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## Aspect at Character Creation

Each character starts the game with three Aspects representing their **Past** (Background), **Present** (Bonds) and **Future** (Drives). These Aspects should be assigned collaboratively during [Session 0](#) and can reflect any kind of emotion and relationship, either positive or negative.

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## Aspects at the end of an Act

At the end of each [Act](#) players can add new Aspects or modify existing ones according to their vicissitudes.

**TO-DO:** - Regulate Aspect change based on end-of-session questions or remarkable situations during gameplay.

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## Invoking Aspects during Challenges

Characters can invoke one of their Aspects during a [Challenge](#). The chosen Aspect should make sense in the fiction, reflecting character's beliefs, traits and emotions. The [Host](#) has the final say on it, as usual.

Once the Aspect is accepted by the [Gathering](#), the active player can reveal one of their [Minor Arcana](#) in their hand. The numerical value of the card will be added to the player's pool and can be combined with any die to generate a [Consonance](#), increasing the amount of [Triumphs](#).

In this guise players can reveal a [Dissonance](#), corresponding to cards with numerical value of 7, 11 or 13.

# Challenge



When the narrative poses uncertainty of outcome, the active player is asked to describe their action and the [Gathering](#) will agree on a suitable [Temperament](#). After that, the player will roll their dice pool and assemble [Consonances](#) to gather [Triumphs](#).

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## Challenge Procedure

Here a step-by-step guide for managing a Challenge:

1. The conversation reaches a moment of uncertainty. The [Host](#) ask one of the players to overcome a Challenge.
2. The active player describes their action. The Host together with the Gathering agree on a [Temperament](#) for the roll.
3. The active player increases their chance of success by:
  - Using any [Minor Arcana](#) card to generate a consonance, or even a dissonance, with a die.
  - Spend a d6 on the [Game of the Goose](#) to re-roll up to two dice on their pool
4. The active player can take dice from their own [Resonance Pool](#) or ask another player for help. Those extra dice can be assembled with the current pool to generate more Consonances.
5. Up to one unused die goes to the active player's Resonance Pool.
6. The active player exchanges their Consonances for [Triumphs](#) and exhausts [Segments](#) of a [Wheel](#) according to the fiction.
7. We have three possible scenarios:
  - A Wheel is exhausted: the active player has full control of the narrative.
  - At least one Segment is exhausted, but not a complete Wheel: The active player shares the narrative outcome with the Gathering.
  - No Segment has been exhausted: The Host has control on the narrative and can generate more oppositions for the player by increasing the rank of a [Wheel](#) for no cost.

# Consonance



A unique way to generate **Triumphs** (Successes) in the *Resonance System*. During a **Challenge**, players are encouraged to assemble pairs of dice in order to generate so-called **Consonances**. Based on the circumstances, Consonances can be tranformed in Triumphs to exhaust **Wheels' Segments**.

## Some math...

The search for symphatetic resonances, unity of opposites and the universal language was an obsession shared by many thinkers and occultists of the Renaissance. Inspired by the principal Pythagorean musical proportions of the - **unison** (1:1) - **octave** (2:1) - **fifth** and its complementary **fourth** (3:2 and 4:3) - **major intervals** of the **third**, **sixth** and **tenth** (respectively 5:4, 5:3 and 5:2)

I have designed a dice-poll system where successes are collected by **pairing dice to achieve consonant proportions**.

Here a table describing all possible pairings given two d6s:

| d6 x d6 | 1      | 2          | 3          | 4          | 5          | 6      |
|---------|--------|------------|------------|------------|------------|--------|
| 1       | unison | octave     |            |            |            |        |
| 2       | octave | unison     | fifth      | octave     | maj. tenth |        |
| 3       |        | fifth      | unison     | fourth     | maj. sixth | octave |
| 4       |        | octave     | fourth     | unison     | maj. third | fifth  |
| 5       |        | maj. tenth | maj. sixth | maj. third | unison     |        |
| 6       |        |            | octave     | fifth      |            | unison |

As you would notice, there are 6 possibilities for **unison** (corresponding to the diagonal of the matrix), 6 for octaves (when the ratio between two values gives 2), 6 for **fifth** and **fourth** and 6 for **major third and sixth**. Each of the four categories is equiprobable, and counted together gives a total probability of success of  $24/36 = 66\%$ .

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## Exchanging Consonances for Triumphs

Each of the aforementioned pairs of dice generates a **Consonance** that can be exchanged by a player for a **Triumph**.

It is possible to increase the number of Consonances by gathering dice from the **Resonance Pool** of a player or by playing a **Minor Arcana** by invoking an **Aspect**.

Each **Temperament** has a privileged type of Consonance associated with it:

- **Choleric** resonates the most with passions, reflected by the colorful consonances of **major third, sixth and tenth**.
- **Phlegmatic** resonates the most with the purity of the **unison** consonance.
- **Sanguine** resonates with the creative impulse of the **fifth and fourth** consonances.
- **Melancholic** resonates with the stability and depth of the **octave** consonance.

Players are encouraged to seek consonance pairs in their dice pool that resonates with the chosen Temperament of the current **Challenge**. If the particular Consonances are dominantly expressed in the final pool, then the player will receive an extra Triumph.



# Dissonance



A Dissonance generates a negative twist in the narrative, causing the reset of the [Gathering's Resonance Pools](#).

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Special combinations of dice generates Dissonances. Those unpleasant sounds are represented in *Sprezzatura* by values of 7, 11 and 13. As long as the player rolls only dice from a character's Temperament, Dissonances can not be generated. The only way to create Dissonance is by playing [Minor Arcanas](#) cards or by some exceptional rules imposed by the current [Major Arcana](#).

A Dissonance always cleans **every** player's [Resonance Pools](#) and generates a negative twist into the character's life. It can be a short or a long-term consequence.

Sometimes, a player may play a Dissonance card on their character. Their [Challenge](#) automatically fails, generating no [Triumphs](#). On the other hand, the player that suffers the Dissonance can grant some advantages in the [Royal Game of the Goose](#).

# Royal Game of the Goose



In *Sprezzatura* players represent their characters narrative long term resources through a race game similar to the [Royal Game of the Goose](#). Everytime a player is using their agency on the narrative, they will roll some dice to move their pawn forward on the board. Similarly, giving up agency provides a way to regress their station. Once a player character reaches station 63, they have to retire from the game.

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## Narrative Resource

Despite many TTRPGs, where players can rely on resourcers like HPs, Stress boxes and Conditions, *Sprezzatura* emulates a character arc through a variant of the most famous race game of all time, the Royal Game of the Goose. During the Renaissance and Baroque eras, the Game of the Goose has been a metaphore for inner growth and the path of life itself. Many variants race games like *Il Gioco del Giardin d'Amore*(1616) have developed the idea of playing with chance on a spiral-like path of stations.

If a player reaches station 63 during a [Scene](#) something remarkable happens to the player character: their finale. According to the fiction, the [Gathering](#) can decide how this last deed looks like: it can be an heroic sacrifice, retirement from adventure or a miserable death.

You can physically deploy a board with pawns, or alternatively record each station position on each character sheet.

## Advancing your station

Here a list of actions that will require the player to roll for advancing their pawn on the Game of Goose board:

- You play a [Major Arcana](#) card at the end of a [Scene](#), becoming the next [Host](#). **2d6**
- You play a [Minor Arcana](#) to influence the result of a [Challenge](#). **1d6**
- You re-roll up to two dice from your dice poll before adding extra dice from [Resonance Pool](#). **1d6**
- You, the current Host, introduce a new [Wheel](#) to the current Scene. **1d6**
- You share your Resonance Pool with the active player. **1d6**

## Revert your station

Here a list of actions that will regress the station value of a player:

- You are willingly exclude your character form the Scene. If you choose so, the Host will provide you instructions in playing as NPC. **3d6**
- Before rolling for a Challenge, you willingly accept failure scoring no **Triumphs**. The Host together with the rest of the **Gathering** will take control of the narrative. **2d6**

## Major Arcanas

Some Major Arcanas can alter the amount of dice to be rolled for advacing or reverting the station of a player. For more information see this [section](#).

# Gathering



Terms indicating the whole playing table, including players and current [Host](#). The word is inspired by Renaissance academies, courts and other learned societies. The members of such groups will gather together regularly to exchange ideas, poetry, music and play parlor games.

# Host



Name given for the temporary Game Master, moderating the session during a [Scene](#). The Host earns their position by playing a [Major Arcana](#) at the end of the previous Scene. Their role is to make sure that every player is engaged in the Scene and that they are acting on a respectful and positive manner. In case of discord, they have the final say concerning rules and their application.



# Major Arcana



According to the tarot tradition, the 22 cards of the Major Arcana are emblems that embeds profound knowledge about the Future, the Present and the Past. In *Sprezzatura* each Major Arcana card alludes to certain tropes of Renaissance imagination and literature, inspiring the [Host](#) in setting up the current [Scene](#).

Each Major Arcana card provides temporary mechanics that will force the players to reconsider their interaction and strategies.

So far, we are not providing a fixed list of effects and rules for each Major Arcana. The powerful imaginative emblems encoded into this cards can inspire the [Gathering](#) in collaboratively set the tone of a given scene.

Here some suggestions of temporary mechanics that interacts with the core rules of *Sprezzatura*:

- Constraint Resonance Pool between players
- Exchange, reduce or increase cards in players' hands.
- Boost or flaw a certain Temperament for the Scene by changing rules about die value, intervals and Consonances. The same applies to [Minor Arcana](#) cards.
- Alters rules of [Dissonance](#)
- Force players to play their main character off-scene.

## List of Major Arcanas

Cards from the [Visconti-Sforza deck \(15th century\)](#)

| Image | Tarot Card | Tropes | Mechanics |
|-------|------------|--------|-----------|
|-------|------------|--------|-----------|



I The Magician

magic, deception,  
knowledge

Players are allowed to keep 4 cards in their hand.



II The High  
Priestess

heroine, quarrel of the  
sexes, virtue

Every Female character may reduce their Failure dice  
by one, up to a minimum of one die.



III The Empress



IIII The  
Emperor



V The  
Hierophant



VI The Lovers



VII The Chariot



VIII The Justice



VIII The Hermit



X The Wheel of Fortune



XII The Hanged Man



XIII The Death



XIV The Temperance

Missing card

XV The Devil

Missing card

XVI The Tower



XVII The Star



XVIII The Moon



XVIII Sun



XX The Judgement



XXI The World

# Minor Arcana



The Minor Arcana cards are the precursors of modern card decks and are divided in four seeds, each one representing a social class of medieval society.

Work in progress...

## Seeds and Temperaments

In *Sprezzatura*, each seed is aligned with one of the four [Temperaments](#).

| Seed   | Temperament |
|--------|-------------|
| Clubs  | Melancholic |
| Hearts | Sanguine    |
| Spades | Choleric    |
| Cups   | Phegmatic   |

- Cards from 1 to 14, four seeds aligned with the four
- [Dissonant cards](#): 7, 11, 13.

## Your hand

- Usually 3 cards. Every time you use a card you can draw a new one from the communal deck.
- Stations that are not prime numbers provide an extra card in the player's hand. If the station value changes during the course of the [Scene](#), the player is forced to discard one card of their choice.



# Resonance Pool



A special dice pool that each player possesses. At the end of a [Challenge](#) a player can save an unused die into their Resonance Pool, to be used in later Challenges during the [Scene](#).

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## Dice pool metacurrency

Many tabletop role-playing games are turn-based, providing few mechanics for other players to interact with the active player taking actions. In *Sprezzatura* I have introduced an interesting help mechanics called the Resonance Pool.

Each time a player rolls for a [Challenge](#), they can save up to one unused die from their dice pool and save it. During the same [Scene](#), a player can require dice from another player's Resonance Pool or access their own.

If the owner of the pool agrees to help the active player, they have power to shape the outcome narratively, introducing a new oppositions in the form of a [Wheel](#) or generating a complication by increasing the number of [Segments](#) of a Wheel already present.

In exchange for their narrative power, the donor exhausts the given dice and the active player can use them to assemble more [Consonances](#), thus potentially more [Triumphs](#).

**Note:** Only one Resonance Pool can be used during a Challenge. The active player can always use their own, or grant help from the [Gathering](#).

### Example

Nicholas' character *Guidobaldo* is involved in a Challenge, trying to impress some local nobles at a party. He is rolling with his Sanguine Temperament of 3 and he rolls a 1,2,5. He can combine (5,2) to generate a major tenth Consonance, but he needs two successes to achieve his character's goal. Lidwien has a 2 on her Resonance Pool and suggests a narrative outcome favorable to her character *Moderata* by increasing the Segments of the given Wheel "Consideration of the Nobles" from 4 (Scene) to 8 (Act).

# Scene



Portion of an [Act](#) ruled by a [Major Arcana](#) card and moderated by the [Host](#) who placed it on the board. Players can choose to interpret their main character or side characters at the beginning of the Scene.

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The length of a Scene is related to the algebraic sum of the Major Arcana's digits. For example, the arcana XXII of the Fool will provide a length of  $4 = 2+2$  to the current Scene.

Given a certain length, the Scene ends when the same amount of [Wheels](#) are exhausted. For example, the players have to complete all the [Segments](#) of  $6 = 1+5$  Wheels to complete a Scene governed by the arcana XV of the Devil.

The longest length for a Scene is given by the arcana XIX of the Sun, forcing the players to exhaust 10 different Wheels.

# Segment



A constitutive part of a [Wheel](#). Players can exhaust a Segment by using a [Triumph](#). Once all Segments of a Wheel are exhausted, the challenge is achieved in the narrative by the players. Some [Major Arcana](#) cards can alter the way in which Segments are exhausted by Triumphs, making the handling of situations tougher or easier than normal.

# Temperament



One of the four main attributes of a player character, representing a PC's disposition on a certain approach rather than modelling a specific physical or mental talent.

## The Four Temperaments

The main attributes of each playing character in *Sprezzatura* represents four approaches called Temperaments, inspired by Renaissance and Medieval theories categorizing people's [personality and physiological traits](#). For each [Challenge](#), the player will describe their PC's action that will lead the [Gathering](#) to an agreement: the chosen character's approach.



- **Choleric** (Fire): associated with creativity and passion.
- **Phlegmatic** (Water): associated with empathy and adaptivity.
- **Sanguine** (Air): associated with reason and wit.
- **Melancholic** (Earth): associated with tradition and care.

A playing character in *Sprezzatura* will have an amount of 6-sided dices (d6s) associated to each Temperament, reflecting their predisposition to the given approach. Each Temperament's value ranges from **2** (weak) to **5** (legendary) d6s.

### Example:

Nicholas' playing character *Guidobaldo Strozzi* is an Italian merchant from Venice, who climbed the social ladder with his wealth and lack of empathy. He has a silver tongue, a passionate soul and no respect for tradition and etiquette.

His Temperaments values are: **Choleric**: 3, **Phlegmatic**: 3, **Sanguine**: 4 and **Melancholic**: 2.

# Triumph



Measure of achievement of a player character in a [Challenge](#). The more Triumphs, the more [Segments](#) of a [Wheel](#) can be exhausted with the PC's action.

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## Adjudicating Triumphs

Under normal circumstances, the number of Triumph is proportional to the number of [Consonances](#) a player could gather with their roll.

There are some ways to increase or decrease Triumphs in a Challenge:

- The type of Consonance could increase or decrease the final number of Triumphs according to the current [Major Arcana](#) on [Scene](#)

### Example

A Major Arcana could reduce by one the number of Triumphs of Challenges where the player has invoked an specific Aspect, or if the player used a specific Temperament for the roll.

- The chosen [Temperament](#) has a privileged Consonance. If that Consonance is dominantly expressed in the final pool, then the players is awarded an additional Triumph.

### Example

The Sanguine Temperament resonates with Consonance of fifth (3:2 proportion) and fourth (4:3 proportion). The player, after their roll for the Challenge, gathers 1 unison, 1 fifth, 1 major third and 1 fourth. The total number of Sanguine-resonant consonances is 2, which is the dominant expressed consonant (the other have a total of 1 each).



# Wheel



Inspired by *Forged in the Dark* Clock mechanics and *Dungeon World*'s Fronts I have decided to represent every kind of opposition facing the players, either abstract or concrete, into Wheels. In the [art of memory](#) tradition, wheels of any sorts where used as mnemonic devices and even machines for generating new knowlegde and rhetorical statements, such as in the case of [Giulio Camillo](#)'s *artificiosa ruota* and the pedagogical devices of [Orazio Toscanella](#). Such combinatorial wheels originates in the Medieval writings of [Ramon Llull](#), and are considered the precursors of our modern algorithmic thinking.

Each Wheel is divided in [Segments](#), which number is proportional to its inherent difficulty.

The rank of a Wheel represent its number of Segments. Players' actions, such as accepting to share their [Resonance Pool](#), or circumstances dectated by [Major Arcanas](#) can promote a Wheel to an higher rank.

Every opposition to the players in the world is mapped into a Wheel, abstracting its inherent degree of difficulty according to its number of [Segments](#).

## Wheels and their rank

| Rank | Number of Segments | Description                                                                                                  |
|------|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Line | 2                  | Wheel used to represent minor oppositions, such as villain's minions or a non-complex task like convincing a |



|       |    |                                                                                                                                          |
|-------|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|       |    | guard or climb a wall.                                                                                                                   |
| Scene | 4  | The standard rank for a new Wheel.<br>It represent some non-trivial task<br>with a certain degree of complexity,<br>or a tough opponent. |
| Act   | 8  | A challenging opposition, usually<br>representing a boss or a complex task.                                                              |
| Opus  | 16 | A problem for the player characters<br>that will play a major role in their<br>chronicles.                                               |

## Exhausted Wheels

Once the [Gathering](#) exhausts a number of Wheels equal to the sum of the digits of the current Major Arcana for the [Scene](#), the [Host](#) can close the chapter and resign their priviledged position.

When all the Segments of a Wheel are filled by players' [Triumphs](#) it is declared as exhausted. In the fiction, this means that the opposition has been resolved by the characters.

# Playing the Game



*Sprezzatura*'s setting might sound very hermetic and specific for the average player of TTRPG. Historically, the hobby has been mostly inspired by fantasy authors who took inspiration from the Middle Ages, Mythology and North European folklore. The imaginary world of (Italian) Renaissance has yet not fully inspired the hobby, due to a lack of modern media supporting it. Players are welcome to exploit some of the ideas and mechanics for their own games. The Renaissance has been an inspiration for this rules, but a skilled Game Master and a flexible group could adjust some of the themes to another setting. Feel free to experiment!

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Here come some example of play, setting a campaign and other useful tips. **Still work in progress...**

## Character Sheet

Template [Character sheet](#)

Example [Character sheet](#)

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## Session o

**TO-DO:** - Defining the World - Player characters - Assigning [Temperament](#) values - Create [Aspects](#)

# References & Inspirations



The Glossary wishes to provide a quick reference and translation of the main elements of the game, using more common terminology shared by the TTRPG community. Furthermore, we are providing a list of sources of inspirations from academia, art, games and literature.

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## Glossary

| Term                              | TTRPG community translations                                          |
|-----------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <a href="#">Act</a>               | A gaming session.                                                     |
| <a href="#">Aspect</a>            | Aspect, Trait                                                         |
| <a href="#">Challenge</a>         | Check                                                                 |
| <a href="#">Consonance</a>        | System to collect successes for players.                              |
| <a href="#">Dissonance</a>        | Disruptive force that players have to confront with.                  |
| <a href="#">Game of the Goose</a> | Long term resource, like Stress, Conditions and HPs.                  |
| <a href="#">Gathering</a>         | Players at the table, including GM.                                   |
| <a href="#">Host</a>              | The (temporary) Game Master.                                          |
| <a href="#">Major Arcana</a>      | Mood or Theme of a Scene.                                             |
| <a href="#">Minor Arcana</a>      | Metacurrency in form of cards, similar to Fate Points or Hero Points. |
| <a href="#">Resonance Pool</a>    | Dice bank for each player.                                            |

|             |                       |
|-------------|-----------------------|
| Scene       | Encounter.            |
| Segment     | Tick of Clock.        |
| Temperament | Attribute, main Stat. |
| Triumph     | Success.              |
| Wheel       | Clock, Front.         |

## Inspirations

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